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Veiled sentiments

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In any case, dictionary searches to determine cultural meanings are of questionable validity. The controversy provoked by Antoun's (1968) reliance on dictionary definitions in his classic article on Arab women's modesty is instructive. *Hasham* is in fact one of the key words on which he bases his analysis. He writes, " *Hishma* refers to bashfulness or self-restraint and *ih'tisham* to modesty or respect, both related to the triliteral root form that means to cause to blush." Thus far the definition suffers only from vagueness. He then adds, "But another form of the same root *mahashim* means pudenda. Many Quranic references to modesty and chastity are literally references to the protection of female genitalia" (Antoun 1968, 679). These definitions constitute part of his evidence for interpreting women's modesty as tied exclusively to sexuality.

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Abu-Zahra's (1970) reply to Antoun's article is multi-faceted. One part of her criticism focuses on his reliance on lexicographic explorations of "museum words" either unknown to the "illiterate villagers" he discusses or whose referent varies across Arabic dialects (Abu-Zahra 1970, 1081). Consulting the most definitive Arabic dictionary herself, she turns up no mention of pudenda as a meaning of the word *mahashim*. Furthermore, she cites very different meanings for the words in both Tunisian and Egyptian spoken Arabic. In attempting to understand how the concept of *hasham* informs Awlad 'Ali society, then, the word's meaning should be sought not in obscure dictionaries of classical Arabic but in everyday usage.

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In daily parlance, words from the root *hashama* are used in various grammatical forms, each having a slightly different sense. The two poles of meaning around which usage clusters are those referring to an internal state and those referring to a way of acting; thus, *hasham* involves both feelings of shame in the company of the more powerful and the acts of deference that arise from these feelings. In  108 the first instance, *hasham* is conceptualized as an involuntary experience (we might even call it an emotion); in the second, as a voluntary set of behaviors conforming to the "code of modesty." The experience is one of discomfort, linked to feelings of shyness, embarrassment, or shame, and the acts are those of the modesty code, a language of formal self-restraint and effacement. The cultural repertoire of such behaviors includes the most extreme and visible acts of veiling and dressing modestly (covering hair, arms, legs, and the outlines of the body) as well as more personal gestures such as downcast eyes, humble but formal posture, and restraint in eating, smoking, talking, laughing, and joking.

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